Yu Wu

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Education

Ph.D. Candidate in Economics Sept. 2023 - Present
National School of Development, Peking University
Advisor: Bo Zhao

B.A. in Economics Sept. 2019 - July 2023
National School of Development, Peking University

Research Interests

Macroeconomics, Labor Economics, China Economy

Working Paper

Labor Mobility under Partial Citizenship: Welfare Effects of China's Rural–Urban Migration
Author with Xuan Wang and Bo Zhao
Abstract: China's hukou system lets rural households work in cities without urban registration. We model these "floaters" in a dynamic two-sector economy in which registration governs income-risk smoothing and access to locally financed public benefits. We estimate the model on Chinese data from 1985 to 2023. Granting today's floaters full urban citizenship is equivalent to a permanent 16 percent rise in a floater's private expenditure—about 73 percent of it from hukou-gated public benefits rather than pass-through insurance or wage wedges. The reform also raises aggregate welfare by the equivalent of a permanent 4 percent rise in expenditure, most of that carried by the labor-market channel rather than by benefit extension. It is not Pareto-improving on its own. Urban benefits are locally financed and rivalrous, so extending them dilutes incumbents' per-capita provision and, by drawing labor out of agriculture, raises the food prices they face. Urban-hukou natives lose the equivalent of a permanent 8 percent cut in expenditure absent compensation. The estimate is a quantitative accounting conditional on calibrated benefit access and public-benefit valuation.

Learning Where to Search: Employer Feedback and the Direction of Job Search
Author with Jiayin Hu, Xincheng Qiu and Jieru Wang
Abstract: This paper studies how job seekers adapt their application strategies over the course of a search spell and how employer feedback shapes this process. Using high-frequency application data, we document three main findings. First, job seekers progressively concentrate their applications in a narrower set of submarkets as the spell proceeds and their rate of positive employer responses rises. Second, a positive employer response from an occupation increases subsequent applications to it. Third, this response is stronger for occupations in which workers lack prior experience. These findings support a learning view of job search in which applications generate information about workers' comparative advantage, leading them to shift from broad exploration toward more targeted search.

Conferences and Seminars

The Fourth NCER-CCER Chinese Economy Symposium	December 2024
The 13th Shanghai Macroeconomics Workshop	June 2025
The 10th Summer Institute	July 2026

Teaching Experience

TA for Intermediate Macroeconomics (Undergraduate) by Prof. Bo Zhao	2022 Spring
TA for Intermediate Macroeconomics (Undergraduate) by Prof. Lintong Li	2025 Spring
TA for Intermediate Macroeconomics (Undergraduate) by Prof. Bo Zhao	2026 Spring

Honors and Awards

Freshman Scholarship, CF40 Scholarship